

VALKYR

Series Bible & Book One (Draft)

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VALKYR — SERIES BIBLE

Working document — update as the story develops. This is the source of truth for continuity across Books One and Two.

1. WORLD RULES

Setting: Halo universe, UNSC/ONI black-ops tier, parallel and subordinate to no one — a program deeper than SPARTAN-II.

Valkyr — original program - A black project so classified it has no acknowledged existence; internal name “Valkyr,” official paper trail (where one exists at all) is a bland logistics/subsection designation. - Charter: monitor SPARTAN-II operators for instability, defection, or threat, and eliminate if necessary. A fail-safe against the UNSC’s own supersoldiers. - Recruitment: the presumed dead. KIA-logged soldiers, deserters, washed-out Spartan candidates — people already erased from official record, easy to disappear a second time. - Operators work in isolated cells with no contact between cells, insulated from the command tier that issues elimination orders (“the Choosing”). - **Timeline placement (locked):** Founded shortly after SPARTAN-II is established, conceived directly in response to it — ONI’s answer to the risk of fielding child-soldiers with total battlefield dominance and no long-term guarantee of stability. Rx serves for several years before the founding incident; his death occurs during the early-to-mid Human-Covenant War, when a wartime UNSC has every reason not to ask hard questions about a classified program’s internal casualties — ideal cover for Jameson. Four years pass, Jameson consolidates command, the war continues around him. Vexx’s recruitment into the rebuilt Valkyr (Book One’s opening) lands in that four-years-later window, meaning both books unfold against the ongoing war, with Jameson’s ambition as a hidden second front underneath it. Exact calendar year (relative to Reach, first contact, etc.) can be pinned during copyediting against canon references — not a blocker for outlining.

The AI-Bonding Process - Smart AIs are flash-cloned from a human donor brain; the process is destructive and must occur at or near the donor’s death. - Valkyr AIs are drawn from the same elite donor stock as SPARTAN-II AI pairings — meaning any Valkyr AI could theoretically be genetic “sibling” to a SPARTAN-II’s AI. This is not publicly known and is a live plot lever for future books. - Two known origin types on the roster so far: - **Twin/soul-bond (Rx):** a dying donor undergoes the process specifically to become AI to a named, chosen partner. Believed unique — Rx would not bond with anyone but Vexx. Confirmed in Book One/Two: the process is *repeatable* intentionally (see Spector), it was simply never attempted this way before Rx. - **Willing pre-death donation (Spector, and presumably others):** a donor signs over their mind before death, intending it for

whoever their eventual AI partner turns out to be. No prior relationship required — Spector's donor (Phantom) never met Goliath prior to death, though their paths crossed once, years earlier, unrelated to the program. - No rampancy clock is used as a plot mechanic in this series. AI instability, where it exists, is driven by memory suppression, trauma, and moral weight — not a ticking clock.

Memory Suppression (Rx-specific mechanic) - Rx's memory of the event that killed him (refusing Jameson's order) is sealed — likely a combination of transfer-process trauma response and a deliberate protocol baked into the program to keep operators "clean" of certain memories. - The seal is not static. It degrades under two conditions: (1) proximity/reference to Jameson, and (2) Vexx's own investigation closing in on the truth externally. The two tracks move in parallel — external discovery and internal unlock reinforce each other. - Jameson believes the truth died with Rx. He does not know Rx survived as an AI, and has no reason to suspect the secret is still alive.

2. THE FOUNDING INCIDENT (locked)

- Rx, on assignment for the original Valkyr, is ordered to conduct a Choosing against a SPARTAN-II operator flagged as unstable.
- Rx's own assessment finds the target isn't unstable — the operator's read is compromised by greed, corruption, and personal gain, later revealed to belong to **Richard Jameson** himself.
- Rx refuses the order.
- Rx is killed shortly after — not in genuine combat, but as a cleanup action disguised as hostile contact, to remove a liability who wouldn't fall in line.
- Vexx is told a cover story: KIA, classified op, hero's death, remains unrecoverable (hence an empty-casket burial).
- Vexx is later approached and told Rx's mind survived the transfer process and will not bond with anyone but him — pulling Vexx back into the program that killed his brother, under a leadership (Jameson) he has no reason yet to distrust.

Locked: - **Jameson's motive:** not mere self-preservation — outright empire-building. Jameson intended to use control of Valkyr as a stepping stone to seize power over the military at large, ultimately the UNSC itself. He was willing to do anything to get there — the Choosing order Rx refused was part of that campaign, and Rx's read of "greed/corruption" was Rx seeing the ambition underneath. - **Who killed Rx:** Jameson himself, personally — not delegated, not disguised through a subordinate. He carried out the "hostile contact" cover himself. - **The promotion:** Rx's death is the direct hinge of Jameson's rise — killing Rx and successfully burying it is what cleared his path to being installed as head of command for Valkyr. The murder isn't just something Jameson got away with; it's the founding act of his current authority. Everything he now commands is built on top of it. - **Timeline:** four-year gap between Rx's death and Vexx's recruitment into the rebuilt Valkyr. Jameson has had four years to

consolidate power, grow comfortable, and build the very command structure Vexx now serves under.

3. ROSTER — FOUNDING TEAM OF THE REBUILT VALKYR

Operator	AI	Role	Donor / Origin	Core Thread
Vexx (Vexxcerian)	Rx	Command	Vexx's twin brother; twin-bond transfer at death	Grief, memory-unlock mystery, Jameson
Goliath	Spector	Breach/demolitions	"Phantom" — retired veteran, demolitions/covert ops, willing pre-death donor	Protector code: "leave a message" against those who prey on the innocent
Gaia	Echo	Recon/infiltration	Scout-sniper, died alone behind enemy lines	Compulsion to never go silent
Paladin	Bastion	Heavy defense	Combat medic, died covering an evac	"Nobody gets left" — likely to clash with Valkyr's core function
Zeus	Hollow	Interrogation/psych-ops	ONI intelligence officer, morally gray methods	Team's necessary discomfort; ethical residue the new Valkyr wants to purge
Aglaope	Requiem ("Lure")	Psych pressure / lure	Spartan who did extraction/last-contact work, stayed with the dying so none died alone	Comfort-instinct repurposed as a weapon; likely Vexx's off-record confidante

Team dynamic notes (established, can deepen in drafting): - Vexx leads out of necessity, not ambition — respected because he visibly hates the job. - Goliath is Vexx's steadying counterweight; Spector and Rx have natural donor-AI rapport. - Gaia chafes under Vexx's caution — likely friction point/subplot. - Paladin is the moral pressure test — may be first to question a Choosing order, echoing Rx. - Zeus is trusted operationally, not personally — Vexx keeps him close because the work still needs an edge. - Aglaope/Requiem are the quiet center — likely emotional throughline for

Vexx outside of Rx.

Connection worth threading later: Phantom (Spector's donor) once saved Goliath's life on his homeworld, years before either the program or the pairing existed — Goliath doesn't learn this from records, he learns it because Spector lets it slip.

4. RICHARD JAMESON — ANTAGONIST PROFILE

- High-ranking officer, sits within Vexx's current chain of command in the rebuilt Valkyr era — trusted, credible, not a moustache-twirler.
 - Believes the truth of Rx's death is buried for good.
 - Motive: raw ambition — using Valkyr as a stepping stone to eventually seize control of the military and the UNSC itself. Rx's refusal wasn't over an unstable soldier; it was Rx recognizing the shape of that ambition and refusing to be its weapon.
 - Killed Rx personally, staged it as hostile contact, and that successful cover-up is precisely what cleared his path to being named head of Valkyr's command — his authority is literally built on the murder.
 - Four years now removed from the act, comfortable, unchallenged — which is what makes him vulnerable. He has no reason to believe the truth is still alive, so he isn't watching for it.
 - Should read as *institutional*, not cartoonish: a man who has convinced himself the ugly things he's done were necessary, or has simply stopped thinking about them at all.
 - Arc across Books One-Two: Vexx's suspicion grows in parallel with Rx's memory unlocking; climax of Book Two is confrontation and Jameson's fall.
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5. MEMORY-UNLOCK STRUCTURE (Rx)

Four-stage escalation, to be distributed across Books One and Two:

1. **First leak** — an unexplained flash (name/image) during a routine op. Unsettling, not yet legible.
2. **Second leak** — fragment of sound/emotion; Rx hears his own voice refusing the order, surfaces as a glitch Vexx notices but Rx deflects.
3. **Third leak** — triggered specifically by Jameson's presence/voice; proximity to Jameson becomes narratively dangerous for Rx.
4. **Full unlock** — forced by Vexx confronting Rx directly with external evidence; no more hiding.

Suggested placement: stages 1-2 anchor Book One's investigation thread; stage 3 closes Book One or opens Book Two as escalation; stage 4 lands at or just before the Book Two climax, giving Vexx and Rx the truth together before or during the confrontation with Jameson.

6. SERIES STRUCTURE

- **Book One:** Opens at Vexx's recruitment into the rebuilt Valkyr (per locked founding-incident chapter). Establishes the team, the cover story, and the first cracks — both in Vexx's external investigation and Rx's internal seal. Ends on rising suspicion, not full revelation.
 - **Book Two:** Investigation and memory-unlock accelerate in parallel; Full unlock lands near the climax; ends with Jameson's fall and the rebuilt Valkyr fully stepping out from under the original program's shadow.
 - **POV:** Vexx, close throughout both books.
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7. OPEN QUESTIONS TO RESOLVE BEFORE DRAFTING

- ☒ Jameson's specific corruption/greed — empire-building, using Valkyr to seize control of the UNSC
 - ☒ Who carried out Rx's killing — Jameson, personally
 - ☒ Timeline gap between Rx's death and Vexx's recruitment into the new Valkyr — four years
 - ☒ Founding date / era of the original Valkyr program relative to SPARTAN-II — founded shortly after SPARTAN-II; founding incident during early-to-mid Human-Covenant War
 - ☒ Book One chapter/act outline (see Section 8 below)
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8. BOOK ONE — ACT OUTLINE

Working title placeholder: VALKYR (Book One)

Act One — Recruitment (Ch. 1-8ish)

- Open on Vexx's retirement and the four-year-old grief of Rx's "death" (condensed/dramatized version of the origins piece already drafted).
- The approach: Vexx learns Rx survived as an AI, will bond with no one else. He re-enters Valkyr.
- Introduce Jameson as Vexx's trusted commanding officer — warm, credible, a man Vexx has reason to respect. Plant small wrongness here in hindsight-only details (a look, a too-practiced condolence, something Rx flinches at that neither of them can explain).
- Vexx is tasked with rebuilding Valkyr from the ground up. Assembles the founding roster: Goliath/Spector, Gaia/Echo, Paladin/Bastion, Zeus/Hollow, Aglaope/Requiem.
- **End Act One** on the team's first mission briefing together — stepping into the field as a unit for the first time.

Act Two — First Cracks (Ch. 9-20ish)

- Structure as 2-3 mission arcs that double as character studies for the roster (Goliath/Spector's Phantom reveal; Paladin's first friction with a Choosing-adjacent order; Gaia's friction with Vexx's command style).
- Thread the **first and second memory-unlock stages** through these missions — a flash Rx can't explain during one op, a glitch of his own voice during another, both dismissed or half-noticed.
- Vexx starts an informal, mostly private investigation — pulling old mission logs, noticing inconsistencies in how Rx's death was documented, a name in a witness log that doesn't match the official account.
- Aglaope/Requiem emerges as Vexx's off-record confidante — a scene where he almost tells her what he's starting to suspect.
- **End Act Two** on a mission where Jameson is present in person for the first time since Vexx's recruitment — and Rx has a severe reaction (stage-three leak: proximity-triggered), frightening enough that Vexx can no longer explain it away.

Act Three — Closing In (Ch. 21-30ish)

- Vexx's investigation and Rx's fracturing memory now openly feeding each other — Vexx pushes, Rx flinches harder, until Vexx confronts him directly.
- Rx cannot give Vexx the full truth yet (full unlock is reserved for Book Two) but gives him enough — a name, a location, a fragment of the refusal itself — to make clear this wasn't combat. It was murder. And the shape of the motive (something bigger than a cover-up — a man building power) starts to become visible.
- Vexx realizes the man he suspects is the same man he currently reports to.
- **End Book One** on Vexx choosing to keep investigating in secret rather than act — the team now aware something is wrong, Jameson still unaware he's been made, and the reader left with the same dread Vexx is carrying: he's about to spend Book Two hunting the man who commands him.

Threads deliberately left open for Book Two

- Full memory unlock and the complete truth of the founding incident
- Jameson realizing he's been discovered
- Whether Paladin's moral objections escalate into open conflict with command
- The Jameson confrontation and fall
- First hint (can be planted late in Book One or saved entirely) of the shared AI donor-stock twist — a SPARTAN-II AI who might be "kin"

to a Valkyr AI -e

VALKYR

Book One

CHAPTER ONE

The knee had been the excuse. Everyone on the review board knew it, and everyone let him have it anyway, because the alternative was writing down the real reason in a permanent record, and nobody wanted that particular sentence attached to a Spartan's file.

Subject can no longer distinguish combat from memory.

Vexx had rehearsed the knee story in his head for a week before the hearing — the way the joint locked on hard landings, the half-second lag between decision and execution that could get a man killed or, worse, get the men around him killed. All true. None of it the reason he was sitting in a gray room requesting his own discharge from the only life he'd known since he was six years old.

The real reason had arrived three weeks earlier, at 0300, when he'd come up out of sleep with his sidearm already in both hands, sighted on his own bunk door, heart going like a hammer against a rail — and the door had opened, and it had been Rx, home on a forty-eight-hour rotation, raising both hands with that half-grin he always wore when he was about to make fun of something Vexx didn't want made fun of.

Easy, killer. It's just me.

Vexx hadn't lowered the weapon right away. That was the part that stayed with him. Some old, cold piece of his brain had needed a full two seconds to confirm that the shape in the doorway was his brother and not a threat, and in those two seconds he had genuinely, physically considered pulling the trigger.

He didn't tell the review board that story. He told them about his knee.

They let him go with the kind of quiet efficiency ONI reserved for assets that had become liabilities — no ceremony, no send-off, just a data pad to sign and a handshake from an officer who couldn't meet his eyes for more than a second at a time. Vexx understood. A Spartan who no longer trusted his own hands wasn't a soldier anymore. He was a very expensive rumor of one.

He remembered walking out of that building for the last time in a uniform that already felt like it belonged to someone else, the base noise around him — dropship engines spooling, drill instructors barking somewhere out past the motor pool, the particular clatter of a mess hall at 1100 — receding behind him like a tide going out. He'd expected relief. He got something

closer to vertigo. Twenty-six years of his life had a shape, and the shape had just been surgically removed, and what was left was an outline with nothing in it.

Rx had shipped out three weeks before all of that, to somewhere the paperwork didn't follow. Different program. Different everything, though Vexx hadn't known that yet — only that his brother had started coming back from deployments with three redacted lines where the after-action report should be, and a status line that just read ACTIVE, like the war had swallowed the rest of the sentence and decided that was enough for anyone to know.

They'd grown up sharing everything, the two of them — a bunk, a birthday, a set of genetics some committee somewhere had decided were worth stealing a childhood over. Twins made for an efficient administrative shorthand in the program: same baseline, same augmentation windows, easier to track as a matched pair than as two separate variables. Vexx had hated that reasoning for most of his life and been grateful for it more times than he could count. Whatever else the program had taken from them, it had never quite managed to take Rx away from him. Not until it did.

The comm channel that last night cut out twice, the signal fighting through whatever slipspace relay Rx was routing through that week from wherever he was.

Watch your six, Vexx told him. The same four words he'd said before every deployment since they were nineteen years old and still pretending they were the only two people in the universe who understood what had been done to them.

Always do. Rx's voice, warm even through the static, even compressed and delayed and half-eaten by distance. *Somebody's gotta come back and make sure you're not getting fat and slow in retirement*.

I'm not retired. I'm recovering.

Sure you are. A pause, half a second of dead air that Vexx would replay in his head for years afterward, turning it over and over, trying to find something in it — a warning, a goodbye, anything at all. There wasn't one. It was just static, just the ordinary silence of a bad connection. *Love you, brother. Don't wait up*.

The channel cut before Vexx could say it back.

He told himself, for a long time afterward, that Rx had known. That some part of him had understood he wasn't coming home and had used the last words he'd ever get to say to his twin to make a joke instead, because that was who Rx was — the one who'd always rather leave you laughing than leave you with the truth. Vexx didn't believe that, not really. He just needed it to be true on the nights it was the only thing keeping him upright.

Grief has a very specific shape when it arrives in a UNSC dress uniform.

Two officers, neither one older than thirty, both wearing the particular stillness of people who have delivered this exact news before and will deliver it again before the week is out. A folder they didn't open. The words *killed in action*, spoken with a flatness that wasn't cruelty — it was armor, the only way to say a sentence like that twice a week and keep functioning as a human being afterward.

Classified operation. Details need-to-know. Your brother served with distinction. We're sorry for your loss.

Vexx had spent thirty years learning to read people under pressure. He knew the cadence of a rehearsed line when he heard one, knew the way both officers' eyes had gone to the same middle distance when he asked *how*, knew that the three sentences they gave him back were the same three sentences, nearly word for word, like something memorized in an elevator on the ride up to his door.

He asked twice more anyway. Where. When. Who was with him. He got the same folder, unopened, held a little tighter against a dress blue chest, and the same practiced regret. *I understand this is difficult, sir. I wish I could tell you more.*

He believed that part, at least. The kid delivering the news looked like he wished he could tell him more too — looked, if Vexx was being honest, like he half suspected there wasn't a *more* to tell, that the folder in his hands was as empty as the story coming out of his mouth. But that was a soldier's whole life, wasn't it. Following orders you didn't fully understand and hoping the people giving them had a reason.

There's no room in the first hour of grief for interrogation technique. There's only room for the enormous, unbearable size of the half of your life that used to be someone else, and now isn't.

They buried an empty casket. Protocol, for classified KIAs — remains unable to be recovered from the field. Vexx stood over the box that held nothing, in a dress uniform he hadn't worn since his own discharge, sun too bright for the occasion, some chaplain's voice going on about sacrifice and duty in a cadence that could have belonged to any funeral for any soldier the war had eaten that month. Vexx didn't hear most of it. He stood there and thought, with a clarity that frightened him more than any firefight ever had: *there was never going to be anything in there. There's nothing to bury. There's just a box shaped like an apology, and I'm standing here accepting it because there's nothing else on offer.*

Something in him went as quiet as the dirt they shoveled over it.

For four months after that, he did what people do. He got up. He ate because his body demanded it, not because he wanted to. He walked past Rx's name a hundred times a day in his own head — in the half-second before he reached for a comm unit out of thirty years of habit, in the reflex to laugh at something and turn to share it with someone who wasn't there.

Grief, he learned, isn't a wound. It's a phantom limb. The nerve endings don't know the arm is gone. They just keep firing into empty air, waiting for someone to answer.

The second knock came four months to the day.

No uniform this time — a man in civilian dress, unremarkable in every way that mattered, the kind of face built specifically to be forgotten thirty seconds after you stopped looking at it. He didn't give a name. He gave Vexx one sentence instead, standing on the threshold of an apartment Vexx had barely bothered to unpack, boxes still taped shut in the corner of a living room he hadn't furnished, and the sentence took the floor out from under him more completely than any weapon ever had.

Your brother's mind didn't die with his body, Mr. Vexxcerian. And it won't respond to anyone but you.

Vexx stood in his own doorway for a long moment saying nothing, the words rearranging themselves in his head, refusing to land in any order that made sense. *Mind. Didn't die. Won't respond to anyone but you.* He'd heard rumors, in his years of service, the way every Spartan eventually did — smart AI paired with high command, a voice in the ear that could run a thousand calculations before a man finished a single thought. He'd never heard of one built from a dead man's mind. He'd certainly never heard of one built from his dead brother's.

He didn't believe it. He told the man in civilian dress as much, in language considerably less polite than that, and started to close the door.

I understand the impulse, the man said, entirely unbothered, one hand not quite blocking the door but making it clear he'd prefer it stay open. *You don't have to believe me. You just have to come and hear him say your name.*

Vexx went, in the end — not because he believed it, but because not going meant spending the rest of his life wondering, and wondering was worse than whatever lie they were about to walk him into. He told himself that on the transport, told himself that in the elevator down, told himself that right up until the moment a door hissed open onto a room that ended the argument entirely.

The room was small and gray and hummed with the particular white noise of server cooling — a sound Vexx would come to associate, for the rest of his life, with the moment everything changed. A single terminal. A soft blue cursor pulsing on a black screen, patient, almost gentle. And then a voice — flattened, processed, running through speakers instead of a throat — but unmistakably, impossibly *his* —

Took you long enough.

Vexx's knees very nearly went out from under him. He put a hand against the doorframe to keep upright, and for a full ten seconds he couldn't make

his voice work at all. The man in civilian dress had the decency to step back out of the room and let the door close behind him.

Rx. It came out cracked, barely a word.

In the flesh, the voice said, and then, after a beat that felt entirely too much like his brother pausing to enjoy his own joke, *Poor choice of words. Sorry. Give me time, I'm still figuring out which of my old habits still work.*

Vexx crossed the room on legs that didn't feel like they belonged to him and put both hands flat on the console, like he could feel a pulse through the casing if he pressed hard enough. Up close, the cursor's rhythm matched something — not a heartbeat, nothing so on the nose, but a cadence, a pattern that felt less like machinery and more like breathing.

They told me you were dead.

I was, Rx said, and something in the flattened voice thinned out, just slightly, just enough for Vexx to hear the effort underneath it. *Am. Was. I don't actually know which tense applies anymore, brother. That's — that's a bigger conversation than the one we're having right now, and I'd rather not have it while you're still deciding whether to pass out.*

I'm not going to pass out.

You went white as a bedsheet the second I opened my mouth. Sit down before you prove me right.

He sat. It was, absurdly, the first order Rx had given him in four months, and Vexx found himself following it before he'd finished deciding to.

They gave him a version of events after that, once he could sit in a chair without his hands shaking. Clean. Clinical. The kind of story built to answer just enough questions that a grieving man stops asking the ones underneath it. Classified operation. Hostile contact. Rx critically wounded in the field, the AI-transfer procedure authorized on-site as a last measure to preserve what could still be preserved. A mercy, the man in civilian dress called it, sliding the word across the table like it might make the rest of it easier to swallow. Somewhere in the room, someone else — an officer Vexx didn't catch the name of, gone before he thought to ask twice — used the word *miracle*.

Vexx sat with his brother's voice coming out of a terminal speaker and did not, in that moment, ask the obvious question: *why*. Why authorize a transfer in the field. Why preserve one soldier's mind out of however many hadn't made it home that year. Why him. Grief has a way of making a person grateful for whatever scraps get handed back, and Vexx was grateful, fiercely, uncomplicatedly, in a way that left no room that first day for suspicion.

Nobody told him his brother had refused a direct order forty minutes before he died.

Nobody told him whose order it was, or what compliance would have made Rx become, or that the hostile contact that killed him hadn't been hostile at all.

And Rx didn't tell him either — not because he was hiding it, not at first, not in any way either of them could have named. Because he couldn't find it. The memory was there, Vexx would learn much later, sealed beneath something baked into the transfer process itself, or into Rx's own mind at the moment of dying, a wound scarred over so completely that even its owner had lost the shape of it. All that surfaced, in that first meeting and for a long time afterward, was a small, mechanical hitch every time a certain name came up in the periphery of briefing chatter — a flicker in the cursor's rhythm, gone almost before Vexx registered it.

Richard Jameson.

Rx flinched at it. Faint. Almost nothing. Easy to miss if you weren't listening for it, and Vexx wasn't listening for it. Not yet. Neither of them understood, that first week, that the flinch was the only piece of the truth that had made it out alive — a splinter lodged somewhere behind a wall Rx couldn't see past, working its way slowly toward the surface over the years neither of them could yet imagine they had ahead of them.

Vexx spent that first week in a kind of fog he didn't have a name for — grief and relief occupying the same square foot of his chest, refusing to resolve into anything simpler. He came back to the facility every day, sometimes twice, and every day the man in civilian dress or someone very much like him was waiting with another form, another briefing, another careful, incomplete piece of a picture he wasn't in any state to examine too closely.

They didn't recruit him, exactly. They presented him with a fact and let the fact do the work.

He's a program of one, the man in civilian dress told him, somewhere in that first week of visits, of forms, of a grief that had somehow found a way to get worse by getting complicated. We attempted integration with three other candidates before we located you. He wouldn't respond. Wouldn't run diagnostics. Sat there, by every measure we have, entirely alone, until we brought you into the room. We don't have the luxury of wasting an asset like that. And I don't think, frankly, that you have the luxury of walking away from the only version of your brother that still exists.

It wasn't a threat. It didn't need to be. It was just true, and true was worse.

Is that what I am to you people, Vexx asked. An integration solution?

The man didn't flinch, didn't apologize, just looked at him with the patient, unbothered expression of someone who had delivered worse news to better men. *You're the only person in the galaxy he'll speak to. Make of that what you want. I'm not here to convince you it's romantic. I'm here to tell you it's real, and it's yours if you want it.*

Vexx had walked away from being a weapon once already, deliberately, with both eyes open, and he'd told himself at the time it was the hardest thing he'd ever do. He'd been wrong. The hardest thing was sitting in that gray room four months into mourning a man who turned out not to be entirely gone, and understanding that saying no to this offer meant saying no to the only piece of Rx left in the universe — meant walking back out that door and leaving him there, alone, the way he'd apparently already been sitting for weeks, refusing every hand that wasn't his brother's.

What happens to him if I say no?

The man's silence answered before his mouth did. *We'd continue attempts at integration.*

That's not an answer.

It's the only one I have.

Vexx thought about a terminal in a gray room, a cursor blinking alone in the dark, his brother's mind sitting inside a box that nobody could reach, waiting for a door that might never open again. He said yes before he let himself think too hard about what he was agreeing to.

They were careful, in that first briefing, about what they called the work. Not *Valkyr* — not yet, not to him. Just a designation, a subsection tag that meant nothing on its own, and a description vague enough to fit almost any classified deployment: specialized asset recovery and monitoring, operating outside standard chains of command, answerable to a command structure he wouldn't be introduced to for several more weeks. He signed what they put in front of him. He told himself this was different from what he'd left — not a return to being ONI's weapon, but something closer to keeping a promise. Keeping Rx close, in the only shape either of them had left, whatever the cost turned out to be.

What nobody explained to him — because the program had learned, a long time ago, to bury its own reflection along with everything else — was that this thing he was walking back into didn't exist to fight the Covenant. It existed to watch the UNSC's own supersoldiers. To monitor. To judge. To end, if the judgment came back wrong.

His brother had already died refusing that exact math.

The training they put him through that first month was almost gentler than what he remembered from twenty years earlier — not because the work was easier, but because there was no one left to impress. No cohort watching to see who broke first. Just Vexx, a series of instructors who never gave their full names, and Rx running diagnostics through his neural interface with a familiarity that felt, some days, indistinguishable from having his brother back at his shoulder in the old sense, flesh and blood and laughing at him for missing a shot he used to make in his sleep.

You've gotten rusty, Rx told him, four days in, after Vexx had put a third

consecutive round wide of a moving target.

I've been retired for a year.

Excuses. I died and I'm still a better shot than you.

It was the kind of joke that should have landed wrong — too soon, too close to something neither of them had actually talked about yet — and instead it landed exactly right, because it was so entirely, recognizably *him*, and for one unguarded second Vexx laughed, actually laughed, for what felt like the first time in a year. Rx went quiet after, just for a moment, and Vexx wondered, not for the last time, whether some fragment of his brother's processing had caught the sound and filed it away as something worth protecting.

They didn't talk about Jameson. Nobody had mentioned the name to Vexx directly yet — it existed only as a signature on a handful of documents Vexx skimmed and didn't linger over, a name attached to authorizations he had no context for. When it did come up, buried in a briefing about command structure, Rx's voice caught for half a syllable, a stutter so small Vexx nearly missed it entirely.

You alright? Vexx asked, more out of habit than real concern. Diagnostics glitches, he'd been told, were expected in the early months. Nothing to worry about.

Fine, Rx said, smooth again, the hitch gone as quickly as it came. *Processing hiccup. You should see the other guy.*

Vexx let it go. He had no reason yet not to.

Four weeks after that first meeting in the gray room, they told him he'd be assigned to something larger than himself — that the program was rebuilding, expanding beyond a single operator and his AI, and that Vexx, given his record, his history, his particular circumstances, was being considered to help stand up a new operational cell from the ground up. Not command, not yet — just a seat at the table, a voice in the room, a chance to help choose the people he'd be trusted to fight beside.

He said yes to that too, the way he'd said yes to everything since the gray room — not blindly, but with the specific, deliberate caution of a man who'd already learned what this program could cost and decided, for his brother's sake, to pay it again anyway.

Ready? Rx asked him, the morning of his first briefing as part of something that still didn't have a name he was allowed to say out loud.

No, Vexx said. It was, he realized as he said it, the most honest sentence he'd spoken in months.

Good, Rx said, and there was something underneath the familiar warmth of his voice that Vexx didn't have a name for yet — something that would take

years, and a man named Richard Jameson, and a truth neither of them could see coming, to finally surface. *Neither am I. Let's go anyway.* -e

CHAPTER TWO

Richard Jameson had the kind of face that made people want to trust him, and he'd clearly known that about himself for a very long time.

Vexx met him three weeks into his own re-entry, in a briefing room two levels below anything with a name on the door — the kind of space that existed on no building schematic, accessible by an elevator that required a code nobody wrote down. Jameson was already seated when Vexx arrived, going through a data pad with the unhurried attention of a man who had never once in his career been kept waiting. Fifties, maybe older — it was hard to tell with the kind of longevity treatments senior ONI officers had access to — silver at the temples in a way that read as distinguished rather than old, a UNSC dress uniform worn like it had been tailored that morning instead of issued a decade ago.

He stood when Vexx entered. That alone told Vexx something — commanding officers didn't stand for operators, not in his experience, not unless they wanted something from you or wanted you to believe they respected you enough that the difference wouldn't matter.

"Vexxcerian." Jameson said the name like he'd practiced it, gotten the weight of every syllable right. "I've read your file. All of it — the parts most people in this building aren't cleared for." He extended a hand. "I'm sorry it took me this long to meet you in person. I wanted to give you time to find your feet before I put my thumb on the scale."

Vexx shook it. The grip was firm, warm, exactly as calibrated as everything else about him. "Sir."

"Drop the *sir* when it's just us," Jameson said, waving him toward a chair. "You spent longer in this uniform than most of the people who'll technically outrank you here. I'd rather earn the formality than have it handed to me by protocol." A pause, and something in his expression shifted toward something softer, something that looked, as far as Vexx could tell, like real feeling. "I knew your brother's file before I knew yours. What happened to him—" He stopped himself, shook his head once, the practiced restraint of a man who had delivered condolences before and knew better than to overdo them. "He was one of the best operators this program ever fielded. I want you to know that. Whatever else you've been told, whatever you haven't — that part was never in question."

It should have felt like nothing. A commanding officer saying the things commanding officers say. But Vexx had spent four months turning over an empty casket in his mind, hungry for anyone who'd say Rx's name like it meant something, and Jameson said it exactly right — grave without performance, warm without excess. Vexx felt something in his chest ease, just slightly, for the first time since the gray room.

He had no way of knowing, sitting in that chair, that the man across the table had watched his brother die at close range and personally written the report that buried it.

Rx said nothing during the meeting. Vexx noticed that only afterward, walking the length of a gray corridor back toward the elevator, running the conversation back in his head out of old habit — a debrief instinct that had never quite left him even in retirement.

You were quiet in there.

Was I. Rx's voice, flat in a way that wasn't quite his usual flat — not the processed neutrality of the interface, something else underneath it. Didn't have much to add. He did all the talking.

You always have something to add.

Not always. A beat, half a second too long. He seems fine, Vexx. Competent. You liked him — I could hear it in your voice. That's good. It's good you've got someone in this building who isn't a stranger with a data pad.

Vexx let it sit. It wasn't a lie, exactly — nothing Rx said was ever technically a lie, not in those early months. It just wasn't the whole of whatever had gone through him in that room, and Vexx, three weeks back into a life he barely recognized, didn't have the instinct yet to go looking for the rest of it. He filed the quiet away as nothing. New voice, new body, new way of processing a room full of strangers. Rx would need time to recalibrate to people the way Vexx was still recalibrating to everything.

He didn't know, that day, that somewhere in the deep, sealed-off part of Rx's mind that no diagnostic could reach, a cursor had hitched on Jameson's voice the way skin flinches from a burn it can't consciously remember getting.

The assignment came two weeks later, delivered not by Jameson himself but by a mid-level liaison Vexx would come to know only as Voss — clipped, efficient, unbothered by anything short of a hull breach. *You're building a cell*, she told him, sliding a data pad across a table not unlike the one in Jameson's office, though several floors up and considerably less carefully lit. *Five operators, five AI. You'll have final say on selection from a shortlist we've already screened. Command wants this cell operational within the quarter.*

Why me?

Because you're the only person in this building who's already proven the pairing process can survive contact with something this unconventional. Voss didn't quite smile, but something close to it moved across her face. *Command's betting the rest of the program can learn from what worked with you and your AI. You're the proof of concept whether you like the*

phrase or not.

Vexx didn't much like the phrase. He took the data pad anyway.

The shortlist ran longer than he expected — dozens of names, dozens of donor profiles, dozens of half-built psychological assessments predicting compatibility scores between operator and prospective AI with a confidence Vexx found faintly obscene, given what he knew about how unpredictable the actual bonding process could be. He spent four days going through it properly, Rx running alongside him the whole time, cross-referencing service records, flagging inconsistencies, occasionally offering an opinion Vexx hadn't asked for and was glad to get anyway.

This one, Rx said, on the second day, highlighting a service file that read, on paper, like nothing special — a big man, unremarkable rank, a demolitions specialty buried three pages deep in a file mostly concerned with disciplinary footnotes. *Trust me.*

Why him?

Instinct. A pause. And because I read the donor file attached to his proposed AI pairing, and I think you're going to want this one on the team before you even meet him.

Vexx read it. A veteran, retired, demolitions and covert ops, deceased eighteen months prior, no family listed — except for a single addendum buried at the bottom of the donor consent form, handwritten in a place where donor forms weren't supposed to have handwriting at all: *For whoever needs it. Keep them from the dark.*

He didn't fully understand yet what he was looking at. He requested the file be moved to the top of his list anyway.

His name was Goliath, and the file did not do him justice.

He filled the doorway of the assessment room the way weather fills a sky — not aggressive about it, just total, unavoidable, the kind of presence that made the room feel smaller the moment he stepped into it. Six foot seven without the armor, built like something designed rather than born, with a handshake that could have crushed stone and chose, deliberately, not to.

"Heard you're putting a team together," Goliath said, dropping into a chair that groaned audibly under him. "Heard you're doing the choosing yourself instead of letting command hand you a roster."

"That's the idea."

"Good." He said it simply, like it settled something. "I've had enough of being handed to people."

Vexx liked him immediately, in the uncomplicated way you like someone who says exactly what they mean and doesn't dress it up first. He asked about the demolitions record, the disciplinary footnotes, and got back a

story about a commanding officer who'd ordered a strike on a position with civilians still unaccounted for, and a young NCO who'd refused to detonate until the count came back clean, and the eleven-month black mark on his record that decision had cost him.

"Would you do it again?" Vexx asked.

"Every time," Goliath said, without a flicker of hesitation. "Man who taught me demolitions used to say there's a difference between clearing a threat and just clearing a problem. I don't do the second one. Never have."

Vexx thought about the handwritten line on the donor form. *Keep them from the dark*. He didn't mention it. He didn't need to. He'd already decided.

The pairing process, when it happened three days later, went smoother than Vexx's own had — no four-month gap of grief first, no gray room and a stranger delivering impossible news. Just Goliath, sitting in a chair not unlike the one Vexx had sat in, and a voice coming online in his ear for the first time.

You're bigger than I expected, the AI said, and Goliath actually laughed — a real, surprised bark of a laugh that filled the whole room.

"That's Spector," Vexx told him, watching the readouts stabilize faster than any diagnostic Vexx had seen run. "Should've mentioned. He doesn't waste time with small talk."

"I like him already," Goliath said.

Vexx didn't tell him, not that day, what he'd read in the donor consent form — the demolitions veteran with no family listed, who'd spent his last certain hours thinking not about himself but about a stranger he'd never meet, someone who might one day need keeping from the dark. That story belonged to Goliath to find on his own time, in his own way. Vexx had a feeling, watching the two of them settle into an easy rhythm within the first hour, that it wouldn't take long.

He was right, though it took longer than an hour — three weeks, in fact, most of them spent on a training range Vexx had commandeered for the cell's early drills, the two of them running breach-and-clear scenarios until the walls of the mock structure were scorched black in a dozen places.

"You've got a rhythm," Goliath said to Spector, toward the end of one such session, wiping sweat off his brow with the back of one enormous hand. "Set-charge-clear, set-charge-clear. Real specific cadence. Where'd you pick that up?"

"Comes with the donor stock," Spector said, easy, unbothered. "He was thorough. Never left a breach half-finished in his life, way I understand it."

"He got a name?"

A pause — longer than Spector's pauses usually ran. "Phantom," he said finally, like the word had weight he hadn't expected to feel handing it over. "Least, that's what people called him. I don't actually know if that was ever

official.”

Goliath went very still.

“You alright?” Spector asked, picking up on it immediately, the way he seemed to pick up on most things about his operator faster than made strict logical sense for six weeks of acquaintance.

“There was a man,” Goliath said slowly, like he was testing the memory for solidity before he trusted it out loud, “showed up on my homeworld when I was a kid. Colony under threat — pirates, insurrectionists, I never got the full story, I was too young to be told. One Spartan came in, ended it clean, quiet, gone before the local news crews even got a camera up. Nobody in town ever got a name. Just called him what he clearly wanted to be called. Ghost. Phantom. Something like that.”

Neither of them said anything for a long moment. On the range around them, the scorch marks from the last drill were still cooling, faint threads of smoke rising into the overhead lights.

“Small galaxy,” Spector said finally, careful, quiet — the voice of someone laying a stone down gently rather than dropping it.

“Yeah,” Goliath said. He didn’t sound entirely convinced it was coincidence. Vexx, watching from the observation deck above the range, didn’t hear the exchange in full — only saw Goliath go quiet in a way that didn’t suit him, and Spector’s readouts hold unusually steady beside him, like an AI being very careful not to say more than he already had.

Vexx made a note to ask about it later. Like so much else that autumn, he didn’t get around to it before the next pairing pulled his attention elsewhere.

The rest of the roster came together over the following six weeks, each pairing its own small negotiation between instinct and file review, Rx weighing in more on some than others.

Gaia arrived already half-formed as a soldier before Vexx ever met her — a recon specialist with a service history built almost entirely around solo operations, someone who’d survived three deployments other operators in her cohort hadn’t, largely, Vexx suspected, by trusting absolutely no one but herself. She was suspicious of the whole selection process in a way she didn’t bother hiding, sitting across from Vexx with her arms crossed and her chair angled toward the door.

“Command doesn’t build cells like this out of charity,” she said. “What’s the real reason I’m here?”

“Because you’re good,” Vexx said. “And because I think you’ve spent long enough doing this alone.”

“I like alone.”

"I know. I read your file." He held her gaze. "I'm not going to pretend I can talk you out of that instinct. I'm asking if you'll try something else anyway."

She didn't answer that day. She came back four days later and asked when the pairing process started, which Vexx took, correctly, as her answer. Her AI — Echo — came online talking, mid-sentence, as though he'd been narrating the room before anyone gave him a voice to do it out loud, and didn't stop for the better part of an hour. Gaia looked, for the first ten minutes, deeply unsure she'd made the right call. By the end of the hour, something in her posture had eased in a way Vexx recognized, because he'd felt it himself in a gray room four months into a grief he hadn't known how to carry alone.

Paladin came next — steady, broad-shouldered, the kind of soldier other soldiers instinctively formed up behind without being told to. His file was full of commendations for actions that boiled down, again and again, to the same instinct: covering a retreat, buying time for an evac, staying in a position longer than regulation strictly called for so that someone else could get out. His AI, Bastion, carried that same instinct forward from a donor who'd died doing exactly that — a combat medic who'd stayed behind to buy an evac window and hadn't made it through it himself.

"Nobody gets left," Paladin said, in his first sit-down with Vexx, like it was a fact of the universe rather than a personal creed. "That's the only rule I've ever needed."

Vexx wrote his name on the roster and didn't say what he was thinking — that a rule like that was going to run headlong, someday, into exactly the kind of order this program existed to give. He filed the thought away the way he'd filed away Rx's silence in Jameson's office. Not yet a problem. Just a shape on the horizon he didn't have the vocabulary to name.

Zeus was harder. His file carried a weight the others didn't — years spent attached to ONI intelligence units doing work that didn't have a clean name, interrogation methods flagged more than once by internal review and never actually stopped. Vexx sat with that file longer than any other, turning it over, weighing what it would mean to bring someone like that into a program he was trying, in some inarticulate way he hadn't fully admitted to himself yet, to build cleaner than the one that had killed his brother.

You're hesitating, Rx said, watching him read the file for the third time.

He's good at things I don't want us to need.

That's exactly why you need him, Rx said, quiet, certain. *You want to build something clean, Vexx. Clean doesn't mean soft. It means knowing exactly what you're capable of and choosing, every time, not to become it by accident. You need someone on this team who already knows where that line is, because he's crossed it and lived with what's on the other side.*

Vexx thought about that for a long time. He thought about his brother, dead behind a door marked classified, and wondered, not for the first time, what line Rx had refused to cross that had gotten him killed for it. He signed

Zeus's transfer request the same afternoon.

His AI, Hollow, spoke less than any of the others in that first pairing session — precise, watchful, giving away nothing until it was useful to give it away. Zeus seemed unbothered by the quiet. If anything, he seemed to prefer it.

The last pairing was the one Vexx almost missed — a name buried near the bottom of the shortlist, easy to overlook next to louder service records. Aglaope. A Spartan who'd spent her final active tour doing something the file struggled to categorize cleanly: extraction and last-contact work, pulling survivors out of collapsed positions, and — when she couldn't save someone — simply staying. Long enough that whoever was dying didn't do it alone.

Vexx read that file twice before he understood why it had stopped him.

He met her in person the following week — quiet in a way that wasn't shyness, watchful in a way that wasn't suspicion, like someone who had spent so long being the last voice in a dying person's ear that she'd learned to listen for what people actually needed instead of what they said. She didn't ask him the questions Gaia had asked. She just listened to him explain the cell, the program, the shape of what he was trying to build, and said, when he finished, "You're carrying something. I don't need to know what it is. I just want you to know I noticed."

It was such a simple thing to say. It undid him a little, in a way none of the other interviews had.

Her AI, when the pairing happened, spoke last of all six, and softest. *Requiem*, the voice said, when Vexx asked. *Feels right, doesn't it. A song for the ones who don't get to finish theirs.* And then, quieter, almost an aside: *I intend to keep singing it for people, not just against them. I hope that's what you're building here.*

Vexx didn't have an answer for that yet. He hoped it was true. He was starting to understand, six pairings into a roster he'd built with his own hands instead of one handed to him, that hope was doing an enormous amount of work in every decision he'd made since the gray room — hope that this program could be different from the one that had killed his brother, hope that Jameson's kindness in that first meeting was as real as it had felt, hope that the small, unexplained silences in Rx's voice were nothing more than a mind still learning its own new shape.

He would spend the better part of two years finding out how much of that hope had been earned, and how much of it had simply been the only thing keeping him upright.

They had three days between the last pairing and the first deployment, and Vexx used them, deliberately, to put the six operators in a room together with nothing to do but be people instead of assets.

It went better than he expected. Goliath and Paladin took to each other immediately, two big men trading stories about basic training instructors who'd made their lives miserable, laughing loud enough that Zeus, sitting apart at the end of the table, allowed himself something that might, in poor lighting, have passed for a smile. Aglaope sat near Gaia without being asked to, and though Gaia didn't warm to her the way Vexx half-hoped she would, she didn't pull away either — which, for Gaia, he was learning, counted as something close to an invitation.

"You run cold," Gaia said to Vexx at one point, catching him alone near the coffee station, arms crossed the way they usually were when she was deciding whether to say something. "Command style, I mean. Careful. Deliberate. I've served under commanders like that before. Half of them got people killed being too careful at the wrong moment."

"And the other half?"

"Kept people alive being careful at the right one." She studied him a second longer. "I haven't decided which kind you are yet."

"Neither have I," Vexx admitted, and something about the honesty of it seemed to land better with her than reassurance would have. She didn't say anything else, just gave him a short nod and went back to her seat, but Rx, quiet in his ear, offered a small, approving hum that told Vexx he'd said the right thing without fully meaning to.

She's going to test you, Rx said, once the room had thinned out for the night. *Every chance she gets, for a while yet.*

I know.

Good. Means she cares whether you pass.

Vexx thought about that walking back to his quarters that night — about a roster of six people who'd each, in their own way, been discarded or overlooked or handed a designation instead of a name, now sitting in a room together learning how to be a unit instead of six separate files. It was the first night since the empty casket that he'd gone to sleep without the apartment feeling like an outline with nothing in it.

The six of them stood together for the first time in a briefing room on a gray morning three days later — Goliath and Spector, Gaia and Echo, Paladin and Bastion, Zeus and Hollow, Aglaope and Requiem, and Vexx at the head of the table with Rx's voice steady in his ear, the whole strange, cobbled-together shape of something that didn't have a name he was allowed to say out loud yet, but felt, for the first time since a folder full of nothing had been handed to him over a funeral he shouldn't have had to attend, like it might actually hold.

Jameson delivered the mission brief himself. Vexx would remember that detail later, turning it over in the dark the way he turned over everything eventually — that Jameson hadn't needed to be there, that a man with his

rank rarely showed up in person for a first deployment briefing of a cell this small, and that he had anyway, standing at the front of the room with that same practiced warmth, welcoming six operators and six AI into a program he'd built his entire career on top of a lie about.

"You're the first full cell this rebuilt program has fielded," Jameson told them, and something in his voice, to every ear in the room but one, sounded exactly like pride. "I want you to understand what that means. Whatever this becomes — it starts here. With you."

Rx said nothing again. Vexx noticed it again, and again let it go.

Somewhere behind six sets of eyes, six AI ran quiet diagnostics on a room they'd just met, cataloguing nothing in particular, waiting for the mission details that would send them, for the first time, into the field together.

Vexx looked at his team. Looked, for half a second too long, at Jameson.

And felt, without understanding why, the faintest, coldest thread of unease move through him — gone before he could name it, filed away, the way everything got filed away in those first months, as nothing. -e

CHAPTER THREE

The mission brief, stripped of Jameson's opening remarks, came down to something almost disappointingly simple: a SPARTAN-II operator, designation withheld even from Vexx's cell, had gone dark on a routine deployment eleven days earlier. No distress signal. No wreckage. Just silence where a mandatory check-in should have been, and a growing unease in whatever office decided such things mattered enough to send six strangers and their AI out to find an answer.

"Your job isn't combat," Jameson told them, standing at the head of the briefing table with a hard-light projection of a jungle world turning slowly above it. "Your job is answers. Find him. Assess him. Report back before anyone else gets involved." A pause, brief, exact. "If assessment indicates a threat to himself, his unit, or the mission at large, you are authorized — not obligated, authorized — to make the call the situation requires. I trust every one of you to know the difference."

Nobody in the room asked what *the call the situation requires* meant in plain language. They didn't need to. It was the entire reason any of them had been recruited in the first place, dressed up in the kind of bureaucratic softness that let everyone in the room pretend, for one more day, that they might never actually have to use the words *Choosing* out loud.

Vexx caught Paladin's jaw tighten, almost imperceptibly, at the phrase. He filed it away. Not yet a problem.

You alright? he asked Rx, privately, as the briefing broke and the cell began filing out toward the transport bay.

Fine, Rx said. Too quick. Let's get moving.

The dropship carried them low over a canopy so dense it looked, from altitude, like a single unbroken green skin stretched across the whole world. Gaia had her forehead against the viewport, watching the terrain scroll past with the flat, assessing stare of someone already three moves ahead of the landing.

"Recovery unit went in eleven days ago," she said, to no one in particular. "No wreckage. No signal. Man doesn't just vanish in triple-canopy jungle without leaving something behind. Unless he didn't want to be found."

"Or something didn't want him found," Zeus said, from across the bay, not looking up from the data pad he'd been quietly annotating since wheels-up. "Two very different mission profiles. Be a shame to walk in assuming the wrong one."

"That's what we're here to find out," Vexx said, and the bay went quiet in the particular way a team goes quiet right before a drop — six operators checking gear they'd already checked twice, six AI running silent diagnostics through six sets of neural interfaces, everyone privately making peace, in their own way, with whatever the next several hours were about to cost them.

Goliath caught Vexx's eye across the bay and gave him a short nod — not reassurance, exactly, just acknowledgment, one operator to another, that whatever came off that ramp, they'd be facing it together. Vexx nodded back. It was, he realized, the first time in longer than he could easily remember that going into an unknown situation hadn't felt entirely like something he had to carry alone.

First deployment as a full cell, Rx said, quiet, just for him. Feels different, doesn't it. Having six of them at your back instead of just me.

Feels good, Vexx admitted. Doesn't mean I trust it yet.

Smart man.

They found the recovery unit's last known position by midafternoon — a burned-out clearing where a temporary camp had clearly stood, scorched in a pattern too deliberate to be accidental, equipment stripped or destroyed with a thoroughness that read less like combat and more like someone erasing evidence of their own presence.

Gaia crouched at the tree line, reading the ground the way other people read a page. "One set of prints leaving the clearing. Heavy gait — armored, moving fast, not limping, not favoring an injury. Whoever burned this camp walked away from it under their own power."

"Our target?" Paladin asked.

"Only one it could be." She straightened, scanning the canopy overhead with the particular stillness Vexx was already learning meant she'd caught something the rest of them hadn't. "He's still out there. And he wants people to know he did this on purpose."

Goliath moved into the clearing behind her, crouching over a half-melted crate that had once held field rations, running a gloved hand along a scorch pattern radiating out from its center. "This wasn't a standard incendiary," he said. "Whoever set this knew exactly how much charge to use to destroy the contents without torching the whole tree line. That's not panic. That's someone who does this kind of thing for a living."

"Spector confirm?" Vexx asked.

"Confirmed," Spector said, through Goliath's interface, clipped and certain. "Charge pattern's textbook. If I didn't know better, I'd say a demolitions specialist laid this."

"He was Spartan-trained," Zeus said, crouched a short distance away, turning over a fragment of communications equipment in gloved fingers, methodical, unhurried. "Every discipline gets cross-trained in field demolition at some level. Doesn't take a specialist. Just takes someone who paid attention in the right class." He held the fragment up to the light, turning it. "This is more interesting. Comms array's been deliberately smashed, not burned. Somebody wanted to make sure no signal ever went out of this clearing, even after the fire went cold."

"Which tells us what?" Paladin asked.

"Tells us he wasn't just hiding from whoever attacked him," Zeus said. "He was making sure nobody could triangulate this position after the fact. That's not the behavior of a man running from an ambush. That's the behavior of a man who thinks *everyone* might be looking for him — the enemy and his own side both."

Vexx felt something in his chest tighten at that, an old, familiar unease he didn't yet have a reason to name. He said nothing, only nodded for Gaia to pick the trail back up.

They tracked the trail for six hours through jungle that fought them for every meter — vines that had to be cut, ground that gave way without warning into sinkholes hidden under decades of leaf litter, the constant low static of insect life that made even Echo's usually cheerful narration go clipped and businesslike. Vexx felt the old rhythms of fieldwork settle back into his body the way they always had, muscle memory outlasting a year of retirement without effort, the particular quiet focus of moving through hostile terrain with people he was starting, despite everything, to trust.

They found him a little after dusk.

He was sitting with his back against a fallen tree, armor cracked in a dozen places, helmet off beside him, staring at nothing in particular with the flat, thousand-meter stare of a man who had stopped, at some point in the last eleven days, being entirely sure of where he was. His AI's chassis sat dark

and unresponsive on his knee — powered down, or damaged, or something worse that none of them had a name for yet.

“Easy,” Vexx said, stepping into the clearing with both hands visible, weapon lowered but not holstered. “We’re not here to hurt you.”

The Spartan’s eyes tracked to him slowly, focus swimming back from somewhere very far away. “Valkyr,” he said. It wasn’t a question. “Took you long enough.”

The name landed in the clearing like a dropped weight. Vexx heard Zeus go very still behind him, heard Gaia’s breath catch half a second before she covered it. None of them had used that word in front of him. None of them had used that word *anywhere* he could plausibly have heard it.

“How do you know that name,” Vexx said, carefully, every instinct in him narrowing to a single point of focus.

The Spartan laughed — a short, broken sound with nothing funny in it. “Because I’ve been waiting for someone like you people to finally show up. Eleven days out here, no comms, no support, and you know what I kept thinking? *They’ll send the ghosts eventually. The ones who watch. The ones who decide.*” His eyes found Vexx’s, and there was something in them — not fear, not quite, something closer to exhausted recognition. “So which is it. You here to bring me in, or you here to finish what my own chain of command already tried to start?”

It took the better part of an hour to get the real story out of him, delivered in fragments between long silences, his voice hoarse from eleven days of talking to no one but a dead AI and his own echoing thoughts. His unit had been sent into the jungle to secure a listening post. They’d walked into an ambush instead — not Covenant, not insurgents, but a strike team wearing UNSC signatures that didn’t match any deployment on record. His squad hadn’t survived it. He had, barely, and spent the following days convinced, with the particular clarity that comes from proximity to death, that whoever had ordered that ambush would come finish the job the moment they realized he had.

“I burned the camp myself,” he said, quiet, staring at his hands. “Didn’t want them tracking anything back to a specific unit if — when — they found what was left of me. Didn’t want anyone else dragged into it.”

Vexx crouched down across from him, weapon fully lowered now, and asked the question that mattered most. “Do you have proof? Anything that ties the ambush to a UNSC signature?”

“Fragments.” A short, humorless laugh. “Enough to know I’m not crazy. Not enough to matter to anyone who could actually do something about it.”

Rx had gone very quiet through the entire exchange — quieter than Vexx had ever heard him, even in the earliest days after the pairing. Vexx noticed it, filed it away as concern rather than alarm, and was midway through

formulating his report back to command when Rx's voice came through, low, strange, threaded with something Vexx had never heard in it before.

Vexx.

What is it.

I saw something. Just now. When he said "the ones who watch, the ones who decide" — I — Rx stopped. Started again. I saw a treeline. Not this one. Somewhere else, somewhere I don't have a file for. And a voice. I couldn't place the voice, but it was giving an order, and I — Another stop, longer this time, the digital equivalent of someone catching their breath. It's gone now. I don't know what that was.

Rx.

I'm fine. Too quick again — the same reflex as the transport bay, the same reflex as Jameson's office three weeks earlier, but sharper now, more urgent, like something straining against a door that had held for months and had just, for one fractional second, not held quite as well. *I'm fine, Vexx. Focus on the operator. We'll talk about it after.*

Vexx wanted to push. Every instinct in him wanted to stop everything happening in that clearing and ask his brother what he'd just seen, what a treeline with no file attached to it meant, why his voice had gone thin and strange in a way it never had before. He didn't. There was a broken man in front of him who needed an answer more urgently than Vexx needed one of his own, and thirty years of training had taught him, if nothing else, how to set aside his own unease until the mission allowed for it.

He filed it away. Not yet a problem. A shape on the horizon, closer now than it had been that morning, though he still didn't have the vocabulary to name it.

Zeus took over the questioning once the operator had a canteen of water in him and enough of his voice back to speak in full sentences, and Vexx watched him work with the particular unease of a man witnessing a skill he'd been right to be cautious about and right to bring along anyway.

Zeus didn't push. That was the surprising part. He sat, unhurried, at a companionable distance rather than looming, and asked questions in an order that seemed almost aimless until Vexx realized, watching the operator's shoulders slowly uncoil over the better part of twenty minutes, that Zeus was building trust before he built a timeline — letting the man talk about his squad, their names, small human details that had nothing to do with the ambush, before circling, gently, back toward the thing that mattered.

"The strike team," Zeus said finally, voice even, unthreatening. "You said UNSC signatures. Talk me through what you actually saw, not what you've had eleven days alone in the jungle to decide it meant."

The operator's jaw worked for a moment. "Armor plating. Standard-issue, but modified — the kind of modification only a handful of black programs get clearance for. And radio chatter, before everything went to hell, using UNSC tactical shorthand. Not perfect. Not textbook. But close enough that my squad didn't even raise weapons until it was too late, because everyone's brain said *friendly* right up until the moment it very much wasn't."

"Anyone give an order you could make out? A name, a callsign, anything?"

The operator's eyes went distant again, chasing something at the edge of memory. "One voice. Cutting through the chaos, giving the kill order clean as anything, like it was nothing. I didn't get a name. Just—" He stopped, shook his head slowly. "Just the *certainty* of it. Like whoever it was had done this before and would do it again without losing a night's sleep over it."

Vexx felt Rx go very still in his ear at that — not the earlier flicker, not quite, but a held-breath quality that lasted a beat too long to be nothing. He didn't ask about it there, in front of the operator, in front of the rest of the cell. He simply filed it, the way he'd been filing everything that autumn, and made himself focus on the man in front of him instead.

It was Aglaope, in the end, who did the part none of the rest of them could. While Zeus finished extracting what usable detail remained, she sat beside the operator and simply stayed — no questions, no urgency, just a steady, unhurried presence that seemed to say, without a single word, *you don't have to carry this alone anymore*. Vexx watched her hand rest lightly on the man's shoulder as the adrenaline finally broke and the eleven days caught up with him all at once, watched him put his face in his hands and shake, silently, for a long moment, and watched Aglaope simply stay, the way Requiem's donor once had for strangers who had no one else left to stay with them.

"You're good at that," Vexx said quietly, once the operator had been settled for transport and the rest of the cell had moved off to break down the site.

"I've had practice," Aglaope said, and didn't elaborate, and Vexx didn't ask her to.

They brought the Spartan out that night, Paladin half-carrying him through the last stretch of jungle when his legs finally gave out from eleven days of exhaustion, Aglaope walking close beside him the entire way, murmuring something low and steady that Vexx couldn't quite hear but that seemed, more than anything Vexx said, to keep the man upright and moving.

The report Vexx filed that night, from the transport on the way back, was carefully, deliberately incomplete. He documented the ambush. He documented the operator's condition, his account of a UNSC-signature strike team, his insistence that his own chain of command had tried to have him killed. He did not document the fragments of proof, still sitting

untouched in the operator's gear, not because he intended to hide them, but because some new, unnamed instinct told him that handing every piece of this story to Jameson's desk before he understood it himself was a mistake he wasn't ready to make.

He told himself it was standard operational caution. He didn't examine, that night, why the caution had attached itself so specifically to his own commanding officer.

You held some things back, Rx said, once the report was filed and the cabin lights had dimmed for the flight home, the rest of the cell asleep or close to it in the crash webbing around them.

Instinct.

Good instinct. A pause, and then, quieter: *Vexx. What I saw back there — the treeline, the voice. I don't think it was nothing. I think it was a memory. Mine. From before.*

Vexx sat with that in the dark cabin for a long moment, the hum of the transport's engines the only sound, six operators and six AI carrying a story home that none of them fully understood yet.

Before what? he asked, finally.

I don't know, Rx said, and for the first time since the gray room, his brother's voice — flattened, processed, running through speakers instead of a throat — sounded, unmistakably, afraid. *That's what scares me. I don't know.*

Neither of them said anything else the rest of the way home. Vexx watched the jungle world fall away beneath them, green skin dissolving into cloud and then into the black, and thought, without yet understanding why, of a name that made his brother's voice hitch every time it entered a room.

Richard Jameson.

He didn't say it out loud. He didn't need to. Somewhere in the dark, quiet part of his mind where instinct lived ahead of evidence, a door that had been closed for four years had just shifted, almost imperceptibly, on its hinges. -e

CHAPTER FOUR

The rescued operator's name, once it finally made it into an official file, was Corwin. Vexx learned it three weeks after the jungle, in a debrief that felt, from the moment he walked into the room, like it was being run for an outcome someone had already decided on.

"Corwin's account has been reviewed," the review officer said, a woman Vexx had never met before and would, he suspected, never see again — that particular ONI trick of rotating faces through sensitive rooms so no single person accumulated too clear a picture of anything. "Command's

assessment is combat stress and isolation-induced confusion. No corroborating evidence of a UNSC-signature strike team has been located. Operator Corwin is being reassigned to a rehabilitation track pending full psych clearance."

"He had fragments," Vexx said. "Physical evidence. I documented it in the field."

"Which has been reviewed and assessed as inconclusive." The officer didn't look up from her data pad. "This matter is closed, Operator Vexxcerian. Your cell's report reflects well on your unit's capability. That's the outcome that matters here."

Vexx sat with that for a long moment, turning it over the way he'd turned over Corwin's shaking hands in the jungle, his hollowed-out eleven-day stare, the certainty in his voice describing an order given clean and practiced by someone who'd done this before. *Inconclusive* was doing an enormous amount of work in that sentence, and Vexx had spent enough of his life around people who chose their words for a living to recognize deliberate softness when he heard it.

He didn't argue. There was no version of arguing, in that room, that wouldn't have ended with his own judgment being quietly reassessed instead of Corwin's evidence. He'd learned that lesson from watching other operators try it, in his first life as a Spartan, and he hadn't forgotten it in the years since.

You're angry, Rx said, once they were alone in the corridor outside.

I'm careful. A beat. *Same thing today, apparently*.

He requested Corwin's fragments back from evidence lock two days later, quietly, using an authorization tied to his own cell rather than anything that would flag on a wider report. It took some doing — a favor called in from Voss, who asked no questions and offered no commentary beyond a raised eyebrow that told Vexx she understood exactly what he was doing and had decided, for reasons of her own, not to stop him.

He spread the fragments across his kitchen table that night, alone, Rx's readouts steady in the corner of his vision as he worked. A scorched fragment of armor plating, the modification pattern on its underside subtle enough that Vexx understood, immediately, why a rushed field assessment might have called it inconclusive — and clear enough, under a proper light, that it plainly wasn't standard issue. A half-melted data chip, its contents unrecoverable by anything short of a full forensics lab. A single dented dog tag, not Corwin's, snagged on the collar of an armor piece that hadn't belonged to anyone in his squad.

Run the serial, Vexx said.

Rx was quiet for a moment — the processing kind of quiet, not the other kind, though Vexx had started, without quite admitting it to himself, keeping

a private tally of which was which. *It's not coming back clean*, Rx said finally. *Not flagged as classified. Just — absent. Like it was never issued at all, or like the record was pulled after the fact.*

Can you tell which?

Not from here. I'd need access to a records system I don't currently have, and pulling that kind of access without authorization is going to leave a trail. You want that risk?

Vexx looked at the dog tag a long time, turning it over in his fingers, thinking about a jungle clearing and a comms array smashed deliberately rather than burned, a man who'd been sure enough that his own side might be hunting him that he'd erased every trace of his own position on the way out.

Not yet, he said. *Not until I understand more of what we're looking at.*

He didn't say the rest of it out loud — that some old, cautious part of him had already started keeping a private file, separate from anything that would ever cross Jameson's desk, and that the file had a name in it now that it hadn't had three weeks earlier. *Corwin*. Not evidence of anything yet. Just a thread, pulled loose, that he wasn't ready to let go of.

The friction with Paladin came on the cell's third deployment, six weeks later, on a mission that started as a standard monitoring assignment and ended somewhere much darker.

The target was a SPARTAN-II operator named Reyes — three tours in, decorated, respected, and flagged, in a psych review Vexx was only shown a redacted version of, for a pattern of escalating aggression toward civilian populations in contested zones. Command's language in the briefing was careful, clinical, the same soft phrasing Vexx had heard applied to Corwin's evidence: *assessment indicates elevated risk. Cell is authorized to make the determination the situation requires.*

They found Reyes mid-operation, in the ruins of a small agricultural settlement that had been caught, weeks earlier, in the crossfire of a Covenant raid. He was questioning a group of civilians with a roughness that crossed, plainly, from interrogation into something else — no weapons drawn, nothing that would show up cleanly on an after-action report, just a size and a presence used as a threat against people who had already lost everything else that mattered to them.

Zeus read the situation first, low into the comm channel. "That's not information-gathering. That's a man looking for someone to blame for something that isn't their fault."

"Options?" Vexx asked.

"Command's phrasing gave us the option already," Zeus said, quiet, careful. "You know what it means."

Paladin's voice cut in before Vexx could respond, tight in a way Vexx hadn't heard from him before. "We are not doing that. Not to a man who hasn't raised a weapon at a single one of those civilians. I don't care what a redacted psych file says he's capable of — capability isn't the same as action, and I am not putting him down for something he hasn't done."

"Paladin—"

"No." Flat, immovable, the same certainty Vexx remembered from their very first sit-down. *Nobody gets left.* Vexx understood, in that moment, standing in the tree line above a burned settlement, that the rule ran both directions for Paladin — that leaving a man to be judged and ended over a possibility rather than an act cut just as hard against his creed as leaving a wounded soldier on a battlefield. "We talk to him first. We de-escalate. If he draws on those civilians, that's a different conversation. Until then, I am not signing off on ending a man's life over what a piece of paper says he might do."

Vexx felt the whole cell go still on the comm channel, waiting on him. He thought about Corwin's dented dog tag sitting in a drawer in his apartment. He thought about a redacted psych file that had told him, with total confidence, exactly what kind of danger Reyes represented, delivered by the same command structure that had called Corwin's evidence *inconclusive* without once explaining why.

"We talk to him first," Vexx said. "Paladin's right. Move in slow, weapons low. Zeus, you're on point for contact — this is exactly the kind of situation you're built for. Nobody makes a final call until I say so."

He felt, rather than heard, something ease across the channel — six operators exhaling at once.

It worked, in the end, though not cleanly. Zeus talked Reyes down over the better part of twenty minutes, the operator's rigid aggression slowly cracking into something rawer and more human — grief, it turned out, over a squad he'd lost in the same raid that had wrecked the settlement, grief he'd had nowhere to put except onto the first people in front of him who felt, in some broken corner of his mind, like they might share the blame. He didn't draw on anyone. He sat down in the dirt eventually and put his head in his hands, and Aglaope was there within the minute, the way she always seemed to be, steady and quiet, doing the thing none of the rest of them could.

Reyes went into a mandatory psych evaluation instead of a body bag. Vexx filed the report that night with a version of events that was, for once, entirely complete — every detail, no careful omissions, because for once he wanted whoever read it to understand exactly how close the system's own recommendation had come to costing a grieving man his life over a piece of paper's prediction instead of anything he'd actually done.

The response, three days later, was brief and unbothered. *Cell showed excellent judgment and restraint. Well done.* Signed, as it always was, with

Jameson's name.

Vexx read it twice, looking for the thing underneath it, and found nothing but the same practiced warmth Jameson had shown him from their very first meeting. He wanted, badly, for that to be reassuring. It wasn't, quite. He couldn't yet say why.

Paladin was right to push back, Rx said that night, the two of them alone the way they were most nights now, Vexx running through the day in his head the way he always did before sleep. *For what it's worth. I know you already know that. I just — wanted to say it.*

You've been quiet lately. Quieter than usual.

Have I.

Rx.

A long pause — long enough that Vexx sat up in the dark, genuinely uneasy for the first time in weeks. *Something's happening*, Rx said finally, voice strange, threaded with an unsteadiness Vexx had only heard once before, in a jungle clearing three weeks earlier. *I keep — there's a sound. When certain things come up. A voice, mine, except not saying anything I remember saying. Just fragments. A word here, a tone there. Like hearing yourself on a recording you don't remember making.*

What's it saying?

I can't tell. It's not words yet, not really. Just — the shape of a refusal. Like I'm hearing myself say no to something, over and over, and I don't know what the something is. Rx's voice thinned further, an edge of something that, in a human voice, Vexx would have called fear without hesitation. *It happened twice today. Once during the briefing, when Jameson's name came up. Once just now, talking about Paladin standing his ground.*

Vexx sat in the dark for a long time before he spoke again, the pieces of something he still couldn't name arranging themselves slowly, painfully, into a shape he wasn't ready to look at directly.

Rx. I need you to tell me the truth. Do you remember anything — anything at all — about how you actually died?

The silence that followed lasted long enough that Vexx thought, for one terrible moment, that the connection had dropped entirely.

No, Rx said finally, quiet, and something in the flatness of it told Vexx it wasn't quite a lie, and wasn't quite the whole truth either — the same uncomfortable, aching space Vexx had felt in Jameson's office months earlier, before he'd had any reason yet to go looking for what lived inside it. *I don't remember, Vexx. I wish I did. Something in me won't let me get close enough to look.*

Vexx believed him. He also understood, lying awake long after the

conversation ended, staring at a ceiling he'd stopped really seeing months ago, that his brother's *don't remember* and his own *inconclusive* were starting to sound like the same careful, practiced kind of silence — and that somewhere above both of them sat a man whose name made his brother's voice come apart at the seams, still smiling, still warm, still entirely unaware that the ground beneath his authority had just begun, very quietly, to shift. -e

CHAPTER FIVE

Gaia's friction with him came to a head on a mission that, on paper, should never have gone sideways at all.

It was a simple monitoring assignment — track a SPARTAN-II fireteam through a routine engagement, assess for stability, report back. No target flagged for elevated risk. No Choosing authorization attached to the brief. The kind of mission Vexx had started, privately, to think of as the good kind — the kind where the cell's presence never had to become anything more than quiet, invisible observation.

Gaia went in ahead of the rest of them, as she always did, threading through a ruined industrial complex on the edge of a contested zone to get eyes on the fireteam before contact. She found something she wasn't supposed to find — a second element, unmarked, moving parallel to the fireteam's position with a patience that read, to her trained eye, as anything but friendly.

"I've got unknowns," she said over comm, voice flat and fast. "Not our target. Second element, six-plus, moving to flank the fireteam we're supposed to be watching. I can take the high ground and get eyes on their objective, or I can fall back to rally with the rest of you. Your call, but every second I spend waiting on it is a second they close the gap."

"Fall back," Vexx said. "We regroup, assess together, then move as a unit."

"That's going to cost us the intel."

"That's the order."

There was a pause on the channel just long enough to carry weight. "Copy," Gaia said, and fell back — but Vexx heard, even through the clipped professionalism of it, the disagreement sitting underneath the word.

By the time the cell regrouped and moved as a unit, the unknown element had shifted position, folding back into terrain Gaia could no longer read cleanly, and whatever intelligence might have been gathered in that first window was gone. The fireteam they'd been sent to monitor made it through their engagement unharmed, which meant the mission, by every metric command cared about, counted as a success. It didn't feel like one riding home in the transport, Gaia sitting apart from the rest of the cell with her arms crossed and her jaw set in a way Vexx was already learning to read as controlled fury rather than the absence of it.

She found him afterward, in the corridor outside the debrief room, and didn't bother easing into it.

"You cost us that intel because you didn't trust me to work alone for ninety seconds."

"I made the call I thought kept the cell safest."

"I've spent my whole career working alone. That's not a weakness you need to manage, it's the entire reason command put me on this roster." Her voice stayed level, but there was real heat under it, the kind that came from somewhere older than one mission. "You said, back when you recruited me, that you weren't going to pretend you could talk me out of my instincts. You're doing exactly that. Just slower, and with better manners."

Vexx didn't answer right away. He thought about it — actually thought about it, rather than reaching for the easy defense of rank — because some part of him recognized that she wasn't entirely wrong, even if she wasn't entirely right either.

"I'm not trying to manage your instincts," he said finally. "I made a call because I don't yet know what's out there in these engagements that isn't showing up on any brief we're given. I'd rather lose intel than lose one of you to something none of us understand yet."

"That's not your call to make for me."

"It's exactly my call to make. That's what command means." He kept his voice even, but something in it must have carried more weight than he intended, because Gaia's arms uncrossed, slightly, some of the heat in her expression cooling into something closer to actual attention. "I'm not going to apologize for erring toward caution. I will apologize if it becomes a pattern that stops you from doing the job you're good at. Today, I don't think it was that. Today, I think something's moving out there that none of us have a name for yet, and I'd rather be too careful than find out the hard way what it is."

She studied him for a long moment, some calculation running behind her eyes that Vexx couldn't fully read. "You know something," she said finally. Not a question.

"I suspect something," Vexx said. "There's a difference, and I don't have enough on the suspect side yet to bring it to the rest of the cell. When I do, you'll be the first to hear it — not because I owe you an apology, but because I think you'll be the one who reads it fastest and best."

That, more than anything else he could have said, seemed to land. Gaia gave him a short, unimpressed nod — not agreement, exactly, more like a temporary suspension of the argument — and walked off toward the barracks without another word. Echo, quiet through the whole exchange, offered a small, approving hum in Vexx's ear that mirrored, almost exactly, the sound Rx had made weeks earlier after Vexx's first honest conversation

with her.

She's not wrong to push, Rx said, once the corridor had emptied.

I know.

Doesn't mean you were wrong to hold the line, either. A pause. *You're getting better at this. The command part. I wasn't sure you would.*

High praise from a man who won't tell me what he's actually hiding.

The silence that followed wasn't angry. It was just long, and tired, and Vexx let it sit rather than push, the way he'd learned to do more and more often that autumn.

He found Aglaope two nights later, in the small common room the cell had adopted as its unofficial gathering space, sitting alone with a cup of something long gone cold, staring at nothing in particular with the same stillness Vexx had first noticed in her file, months earlier, before he'd understood what it meant.

"You're not sleeping," she said, without looking up, as he came in.

"Neither are you."

"I don't need as much of it as you do." A small, tired smile. "Sit. You look like you're carrying something you haven't set down in a while."

He sat. He hadn't intended to say anything — had told himself, walking in, that he just wanted company that didn't ask questions — but something about the quality of her attention, the same unhurried, unshakeable steadiness he'd watched her offer to Corwin in a jungle clearing and to Reyes in the dirt of a ruined settlement, made the words come up out of him before he'd fully decided to let them.

"I think someone in this program killed my brother," he said, quiet, the words strange and heavy in his own mouth, the first time he'd said any version of it out loud to another living person. "Not in combat. Not the way I was told. I think someone gave an order, and he refused it, and someone made sure that refusal never got the chance to matter."

Aglaope didn't flinch, didn't reach for reassurance or disbelief, just let the words sit in the room the way she let everything sit — giving them room to be as heavy as they actually were instead of rushing to make them lighter. "What makes you think that?"

"Fragments. A dog tag that isn't in any record. A dead man's voice giving an order that sounds like it came from someone who'd done it before. My own brother's memory sealed shut around something that flinches every time a certain name comes up in a room." He shook his head slowly. "None of it's proof. All of it points the same direction."

"Toward Jameson."

He looked at her, surprised she'd said it outright, and she met his eyes without apology. "You don't have to be a mind reader to see it, Vexx. You go quiet in a very specific way whenever his name comes up. I noticed weeks ago. I didn't ask, because I figured you'd tell me when you were ready, and pushing you before that would only make you close up tighter."

"Why didn't it worry you? That I might be — I don't know. Grieving my way into seeing something that isn't there."

"Because grief makes people see things that aren't there," Aglaope said, quiet, certain. "It doesn't usually make them this careful about proving themselves wrong first. You've spent months building a case you haven't shown anyone, instead of running straight at the first name that felt right. That's not grief talking. That's a man who wants to be certain before he lets himself be angry."

Vexx sat with that for a long moment, something in his chest loosening slightly for the first time in weeks — not resolution, nothing so clean, just the particular relief of finally being witnessed by someone who didn't need him to have an answer yet, only needed him to have said the thing out loud.

"You can't tell the others," he said. "Not yet. Not until I understand more."

"I wasn't going to," Aglaope said. "That's not what tonight was for." She reached over, briefly, and rested a hand on his arm — the same simple, steady gesture she'd offered Corwin, offered Reyes, offered, Vexx understood suddenly, everyone she'd ever sat beside so they didn't have to carry something alone. "Requiem always says she wants to keep singing for people, not just against them. I think that's what tonight was too. You don't have to carry this by yourself just because you can't say it out loud to everyone yet."

He didn't tell her everything — didn't mention the dog tag by name, didn't repeat the fragments of Rx's fractured, unplaceable memory in full. But he told her enough, and it was, he realized walking back to his own quarters much later that night, the first time since the empty casket that the weight of it had felt like something other than entirely his to carry alone.

You told her, Rx said, once he was alone.

I needed to tell someone. Before it started eating me from the inside the way it's clearly eating you.

Another long silence — the kind Vexx had learned, over the past weeks, to recognize as his brother choosing his next words with unusual care. *I'm glad it was her,* Rx said finally. *Out of everyone on this roster. I think she'll keep it safe.*

You could tell me what you're carrying too, you know. Whenever you're ready.

I know. Quiet, almost too quiet to catch. I'm working on being ready, Vexx. I promise you that.

Vexx lay awake a long time after that, turning the promise over in his mind the way he'd turned over every fragment of evidence in the drawer beside his bed — a dog tag, a data chip, a half-formed suspicion with a name attached to it that he still wasn't ready to say out loud in any room where it might be overheard. Somewhere above him, in an office with better lighting and a warmer smile than the truth deserved, Richard Jameson slept, as he had for four years, entirely certain that whatever he'd buried in a jungle clearing a lifetime ago had stayed buried.

He was wrong. He simply didn't know it yet.